Drop Dead Gorgeous - Screenplay

By Lona Williams

GLADYS: **(Pg 48)** Welcome to the Mount Rose American Teen Princess Pageant. Every contestant you'll meet tonight is special and unique, [and] they all have one thing in common. They're all "Proud - to - be - an - American!" **(Pg 4-5)** I know what some of you say, "Pageants are old fashioned" and "demeaning" to the girls -- things are different here in Mount Rose! **(Pg 9-10)** When I was seventeen, I was crowned American Teen Princess. And this year. . . drum roll please, my daughter, Rebecca Ann Leeman is competin'.

BECKY: *(holding a 9 mm which she loads while she is speaking)* Hi, I'm Rebeca Leeman, [president of the] Lutheran Sisterhood Gun Club. My mom gave me this nine-mil for my 13th birthday. I'll always remember what she wrote in the card: "Jesus loves winners." That's why, no matter what I do . . . *(shoves magazine back into her pistol)* I aim to win. *(smiles to camera, then kisses her 9 mm)*

TESS: **(Pg 11)** *(holding a dachshund)* Tess Weinhaus *(fake smile as Kenny licks her face)* This is Kenny. Spike, my German Sheperd, went to live with on a farm after he attacked me. *(quick to reassure)* It wasn't his fault. I had beef jerky in my front pocket. *(pulls up shirt)* They re-made my belly with skin from my butt.

AMBER: **(Pg 9)** *(sweet as pie, with a wide-eyed expression)* Hi, I'm Amber Atkins. **(Pg 20-21)** I got dreams of getting' out of Mount Rose and bein' a big-time reporter like Diane Sawyer. I mean, guys get out of Mount Rose all the time for hockey scholarships or prison. But the pageant's kinda my only chance. *(she's interrupted)*

AMBER'S MOM, ANNETTE: *(off stage, yelling, coughing)* Hey, Amber, y'get my smokes?

AMBER: *(fake smile)* That's my mom. *(yelling offstage)* I'll get them in a sec!

GLADYS: **(Pg 46)** Tomorrow night, all but one of these girls will walk out of here a loser.

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INTRODUCTION

*In the heart of small-town Minnesota, where the American Dream wears a sash and heels, the American Teen Princess Pageant isn't just a competition — it's survival. Every year girls with big hair and even bigger dreams take the stage. For some, it's tradition. For others, it's escape. For one… it's destiny. And somewhere between patriotic speeches, talent routines, and suspicious "accidents," we begin to realize that in Mount Rose . . . Winning isn't everything. It's the **only** thing.*

Welcome to Drop Dead Gorgeous; screenplay by Lona Williams — where the smiles are bright, and the competition is fierce.

VOICE OVER: *(music plays)* **(Pg 24-25)** Judge #1 John Dough!

JOHN: Never judged a pageant before in my life. Nope. Never around young girls. Even if I was, why would I wanna be, y'know? I-I-I don't get off on that kinda . . .

VOICE OVER: Judge #2: Harold Vilmes!

HAROLD: I get made a judge, then the furniture store hires us to paint the whole damn thing. *(removing cap)* We're gonna use the money to get our mamma a proper headstone. Oh, and move her out to the cemetery.

VOICE OVER: Judge #3: Jean Kangas!

JEAN: *(meek, middle-aged – she simply waves to the audience)*

GLADYS: **(Pg 23)** The "Judges Interview -- *(to girls)* Remember the judges are as nervous as you are.

VOICE OVER: [What makes you] **(Pg 48)** proud to be an American?

BECKY: Mount Rushmore, because to live in a country where you can take an ugly old mountain and put faces on it, faces of great Americans, who did so much to make our country super great, well that makes me -- Rebecca Leeman – PROUD TO BE AN AMERICAN!

TESS: **(Pg 50)** *(awkwardly)* Uh . . . my Uncle Phil's World's Largest Ball of Twine, in Bundy Minnesota, makes me . . . um . . . it makes me proud I'm American. *(embarrassed)* I kinda misunderstood the assignment.

HAROLD: **(Pg 42)** [Okay, next question] *(looking at his clipboard, has trouble reading)* Uh . . . If you could be any tree in the woods, what kind of tree would you be?

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TESS: *(long pause, then brightly)* Dogwood! *(barks)*

BECKY: One with a strong roots, a solid Christian trunk and long leafy branches to provide shade for handicap kids on a hot summer day.

HAROLD: **(Pg 44)** Amber Atkins . . . Name and spell all the United States in alphabetical order.

AMBER: Seriously? *(can't believe what she's hearing)* Well, Alabama: A-L-A-B-A-M-A . . . *(continues spelling in fast motion, silently, then a bit out of breath)* . . . Wyoming: W-Y-O-M-I-N-G *(Harold hoots and hollers, gives Amber a standing ovation, clapping awkwardly)*

****** The Talent Competition*****

LESLIE: **(Pg 55-56)** *(in her cheerleading uniform performs an amazingly "sexy" wrestling cheer)* Roll him over *(clap, clap, clap)* Lay him flat *(clap, clap, clap)* Pin his shoulders *(clap, clap, clap)* To the mat *(clap, clap, clap)* Yeahhhh! *(jumps and kicks) (applause!)*

GLADYS: **(Pg 57)** *(backstage)* Amber, I hate to be the bearer of bad news, but rules state that a costume must be okay'd at least a week in advance. And this . . . *(pointing at Amber's costume)* ***This*** is why we have the rule. I couldn't allow this on stage! We have kids in the audience!

AMBER: **(Pg 56-57)** This, this . . . This is bulls***!

IRIS: Amber Atkins! That is not American Teen Princess language!

AMBER: Good, because this isn't an American Teen Princess Pageant -- it's, it's Nazi Germany! **(Pg 9)** [I only] signed up because two of my favorite people in the world competed. My mom and Diane Sawyer . . . I hope I end up more like Diane Sawyer than my mom.

AMBER'S MOM, ANNETTE: *(overhearing)* Amber! *(storms off)*

AMBER: **(Pg 35)** *(as camera's swoop in, Amber readjusts for the audience, sweet as pie again)* Oh no! Is my mom okay? *(exits to find her mother)*

GLADYS: **(Pg 56-57)** *(motions the cameras to follow as the returns to the stage)* Now, with overwhelming pride, I introduce contestant number 6 – Rebecca Ann Leeman! (Pg 23) She's been singin' and dancin' since she was knee high to a pig's eye.

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BECKY: *(applause as Becky takes the stage with a mic. She wears a poodle skirt, sweater . . . music)* I've got a very special fella in my life. I do . . . And if nobody minds, I'd like to sing a little song, just for him. *(to the tune of I Can't Take My Eyes Off You, she sings)* You're just too good to be true. / Can't take my eyes off of you. You'd be like Heaven to touch. I wanna hold you so much . . . *(time lapse)*

GLADYS: **(Pg 60)** Boy, I'd hate to follow that. Wow! **(Pg 54)** Our next contestant . . Tess Weinhaus!

TESS: *(droning on at the microphone)* The beagle is known for it's howl. "Aaauuuhhh." The Pekinese has it's own distinctive bark. "Yip, yip, yip." Not to be confused with the Chihuahua's, "Yap, yap, yap."

******Cut to Backstage******

AMBER: **(Pg 37-39)** Mom, uh . . . . I'm – I'm – oh God . . . *(starts to cry)*

AMBER'S MOM, ANNETTE: *(always with her cigarette)* Oh-Jesus-Mary-n-Joseph, pregnant!? If you are, sweetie . . .

AMBER: Mom!!! First of all, I'm not pregnant. *(deep breath)* Okay. I'm thinkin' . . . I-I-I'm gonna quit the pageant. *(softly)* It's scary.

AMBER'S MOM, ANNETTE: Let me tell you "scary," Amber. Look at me. I'm a "lifer" here. Best I can hope for is to end up in a decent "raisin ranch" where they'll change me twice a day. *(smiling)* Amber, this pageant is your ticket out of here. I know you can win! I love you so much.

******* Back on-stage********

GLADYS: **(Pg 60)** *(pauses as Iris runs on stage and whispers something in her ear)* I was just told that contestant number 7, Lisa Swenson, has quit the pageant.

LISA: *(runs out on stage)* **(Pg 59)** And since **my** costume was okay'd a month ago, I'm givin' it to Amber!

GLADYS: *(with no other option)* **(Pg 61)** . . . Number 8, Amber Atkins . . . *(Music)*

AMBER: *(steps to center stage and performs an amazing tap dance routine. May include moon walking, River Dancing and moves never seen before. Make this hilarious)*

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****** Final Awards Ceremony in progress******

GLADYS: (Pg 63) *(DRUM ROLL; opens envelope)* And the 1st runner-up is . . . contestant #8, Amber Atkins. *(shock and disbelief, but then Amber steps forward to take the trophy)*

AMBER: (Pg 65) *(tearing up)* Well, at least, y'know, I got to perform. And Mom got to see me.

GLADYS: (Pg 63-64) *(ushers Amber aside)* And finally, the moment I know I've been waiting for . . . she'll be competin' for the title of Minnesota American Teen Princess . . . my daughter – Number 7, Rebecca Ann Leeman!

BECKY: (Pg 65) *(almost manically rushes forward)* Goodness-gracious, it hardly seems real, y'know? I mean, I won! *I'm the winner!* *(with each photo she changes her smile and expression. She loves this)*

AMBER'S MOM, ANNETTE: (Pg 64) *(from the audience, still chain smoking)* We was robbed!

******* The next day: Main Steet – Pageant Parade*******

MAYOR: (Pg 67) *(into bullhorn)* Welcome to our first ever American Teen Princess Parade – which also happens to be the unveiling of our new sewer system! While Becky gets on her float, any questions about the new sewer?

BECKY: (Pg 68) *(as Gladys helps her climb onto the float)* It smells funny. Like gasoline. My dress'll reek.

GLADYS: C'mon, Rebecca. This [swan float] cost your dad a pretty penny. Now get your a** up there and show me some teeth!

AMBER'S MOM, ANNETTE: (Pg 64) *(near the float, still chain smoking)* We was robbed! *(creepy, sinister smile; then takes out lighter to light another cigarette)* . . . *(Suddenly, like a gasoline soaked pinata, the float EXPLODES!)*

******* Days later – Funeral*******

PASTOR: (Pg 71-72) That's why, dear Lord, it's with such great sorrow that we turn over to you a young woman whose dream of ridin' on a giant swan brought about her untimely death.

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IRIS: *(approaches Amber)* As actin' President of the Mount Rose Civil Servettes, it's my duty since Becky can't fulfill her duties – cause she's dead-n-all – to make you Mount Rose American Teen Princess. *(puts tiara on Amber)*

AMBER: **(Pg 73)** Oh my God . . . Okay, okay . . . *(squeals)* I only got four days . . . I gotta practice! *(turns to cameras)* **(Pg 49)** Living in a country where no matter who you are or where you come from, you can grow up and become what you've always dreamed of, makes me, Amber Atkins, proud to be an American!

AMBER'S MOM, ANNETTE: *(off stage, yelling, coughing)* Hey, Amber, y'get my smokes?

SOURCE INFORMATION

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https://cemp.ac.uk/scriptzone/script.php?type=download&id=182
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